than men presents a stark half-empty glass: 50.6 per cent in rural areas and 51.8 per cent in urban areas, states the Economic Survey. After analysing the core issues behind this endemic problem, the state on its part has launched several programmes for skill development and employment generation. It conducted the Additional Skill Acquisition Programme and job melas with the participation of private companies, and offered additional courses in Artificial Intelligence, blockchain technology, big data analysis and gene editing etc.

Now, the higher education department has decided to introduce four-year honours degree courses, with additional focus set on research and internship in the fourth year. "Quality human resources can only help the state scale up and develop in the future. So, we need to equip our youth to get the best exposure and skills to compete in the global job market. The state government has decided to introduce three pathways in our undergraduate (UG) curriculum with three-year degree, four-year honours degree and four-year honours degree courses with research from the next academic year," Dr R. Bindu, minister for higher education, told INDIA TODAY, adding, "We want Kerala students to be second to none."

Kerala introduced the semester system and credit rating at the degree level in 2011. The state admits 23,301 students every year in 1,200 colleges. Now, the students will be awarded honours degrees on achieving 177 credits in the fourth year, which will primarily focus on internships and research activities. There will also be a provision to exit after three years with a UG degree by securing 133 credits.

The students will have more freedom to choose minor and major courses. Currently, in three-year degree courses, they study one main subject and two subsidiaries. The four-year honours course will entail triple majors with special courses in language and communication skills. Honours students who want to undertake research projects shall do three additional courses of 12 credits each in the fourth year. The selection criteria for this shall be as per the guidelines of the UGC or universities.

Students have to undergo three phases during the academic term—foundation components, disciplines under major and minor subjects; special focus on foundational theories, concepts, perspectives, principles and methods; and critical thinking essential for taking up advanced courses.

The General Foundation Courses—common for all students—will help them enhance their ability to value-add in academics and multidisciplinary courses. The Ability Enhancement Courses are designed to achieve competency in a modern Indian language and in the English language, with special emphasis on improving communication skills.

40% OF KERALA'S EDUCATED YOUTH HAVE HISTORICALLY REMAINED JOBLESS. THE FOUR-YEAR DEGREE AIMS TO BREAK THAT RUT

A comprehensive software named K-Reap (Kerala Resource for Education Administration and Planning) will be rolled out to bring the academic and administrative affairs of universities, colleges and related institutions under one umbrella. Students can access all services on the portal—admission, course registration, progress tracking, assessments, examinations, results, credit transfers and certificate distribution.

In 2021, the Pinarayi Vijayan government had appointed eminent academic Shyamdas Balakrishna Menon, former vice-chancellor of Dr B.R. Ambedkar University, Delhi, to recommend reforms in higher education. Acting on his recommendations, a committee was set up under the chairmanship of Dr Suresh Das, former executive vice-president of the Kerala State Council for Science, Technology and Environment, to suggest a curriculum framework. The panel's framework has now been provided to universities to prepare syllabi and customise courses.

"We conducted several rounds of talks with student unions, teachers and administrators before launching the reforms. During the next year, we are planning to introduce new training modules for teachers and administrators. I'm hopeful that the students will benefit in a mega way and find more job opportunities in their respective fields," adds Bindu.

According to K. Sudheendran, assistant professor at the Physics department of Sree Kerala Varma College who is working as a special officer in Kerala State Higher Education Council, the reforms will improve the academic ecosystem on Kerala campuses. "Kerala youth must acquire several skills and knowledge in their respective fields to compete globally. Currently, all global universities are following four-year undergraduate semester courses with credit ratings whereas we have been sticking to marks-based academics with semesters. This prevented many bright students from getting admissions in prestigious universities for postgraduation as they had undergone only three-year degree courses," he points out.

Teething troubles have started creeping in as the revamp demands more skills for the teachers. But the step is expected to help the students have a deeper understanding of their respective subjects to grab career opportunities. ■